Interpreting student contributions accurately

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D18-S1

When a contribution is difficult to interpret, check your understanding before judging the subject reasoning. Give the student a chance to complete the idea and confirm or correct your interpretation. Clarity is a shared communication responsibility.

A short response sequence

- Listen to the complete contribution and allow thinking time. Avoid interrupting to correct language unless clarification is needed to continue.
- Identify the specific point you are unsure about. Ask for repetition of a key term or a written word if that would help.
- Restate your understanding tentatively: “I think you are saying … Have I understood?”
- Allow the student to correct or extend the interpretation. If necessary, invite a diagram, example or brief written explanation.
- Once the meaning is clear, respond to the disciplinary reasoning. Explain whether the claim, evidence or connection needs further work.

Example - Economics

Student: “Price goes up now but not keep because companies more.”

Teacher: “Do you mean the price increase is temporary because firms will increase supply, or are you suggesting another explanation?”

After confirmation: “What conditions would allow firms to increase supply, and how quickly could that happen?”

If the meaning remains unclear

1. Say which part you understood and which part needs clarification.
2. Offer a moment to make notes or return to the contribution shortly.
3. In a discussion, do not turn the student into a public language exercise or require another student to translate for them.

Phrases to adapt

Invite completion: “Take a moment. I would like to hear the rest of your explanation.”

Clarify a term: “When you say ‘capacity’, do you mean the maximum output or the current output?”

Check your interpretation: “I think your claim is that the second design is safer because the load is distributed. Is that right? Please correct me if I have missed something.”

Offer another way to explain: “Could you point to the part of the diagram you mean, or sketch the relationship?”

Respond to reasoning: “I understand the distinction now. What evidence supports that explanation?”

Avoid leading the student: A paraphrase can accidentally supply reasoning the student has not expressed. Keep it close to what you heard, signal uncertainty and leave room for another explanation. Where possible, use an open clarification question before offering alternatives.

Check your own response: Ask yourself- Did I confirm the meaning? Did I give the student room to disagree? Did I evaluate the relevant subject knowledge? In assessment, follow the approved criteria and rules for clarification; do not provide hints that change the task.

Supporting Sources

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). *Communication Tips*.